A Note from the Author

While researching *The Pilot's Wife*, I read about Glashütte, a small watchmaking town in eastern Germany. During World War II, three thousand forced laborers, including a handful of French women, worked in armament factories there. In October 2024, I traveled to Glashütte to interview people and see what I could find in local archives. During an interview with the Director of the lovely Watchmaking Museum, I told him I intended to write a story about two French sisters forced to work in Glashütte during the war. He immediately corrected me, saying that no French citizens were forced to work in Germany. Other nationalities such as Poles, Russians and Hungarians were forced, but the French were all volunteers. His response left me shaken and it made me rethink the story I wanted to write.

Out of the nearly 12 million foreign laborers in Germany during the war, the largest group came from the Soviet Union—4.7 million people rounded up during the invasion of Russia and sent to Germany. The second-largest group came from France, with 2.3 million volunteers. Many of these workers were POWs who changed their status from prisoner to worker, or they were young men sent by the Vichy regime under its Service du Travail Obligatoire (Forced Labor Service) instead of military service. According to Camille Fauroux's research, 80,000 French women 'volunteered' to work in Germany. I had never heard or read about these women.

In her memoir *The War*, Marguerite Duras writes that in 1945, while she was at the Gare d'Orsay, a repatriation center for people returning to France, she saw women sitting on the platform. They were called 'scum' and threatened with six months in prison because they'd just returned from working in Germany. According to Fauroux, many of the women who